

Ready to Launch	
MODULE OVERVIEW	
Grade 12	
Module Type	Issue
Length of Instructional Time	1-3 weeks
Module Summary	“Ready to Launch” asks twelfth-grade students to write and present a commencement speech for their own upcoming graduation ceremony. It presents a deceptively simple rhetorical situation and genre, but working through the process they will use to create the speech will allow students to apply many of the skills and rhetorical moves they have learned in the ERWC to an authentic opportunity for authorship. The issue is personal and relevant to students—a culminating commentary on the meaning of their own education and high school experience, reflected upon and crafted to share with a specific audience. This module is designed to enliven the strange and wonderful time at the end of students’ senior year. The title refers to the moment just prior to lift-off, when the launch tower pulls away from the rocket as it prepares to begin its ascent. Designed to take between one and three weeks, it is easily expandable in many directions to fill available class time.
Questions at Issue	• How can prior learning be leveraged to address a new task or situation? • How does careful consideration of the rhetorical situation contribute to effective and meaningful composition? • How do genre conventions create opportunities for writers to contribute to the creation of knowledge?
Module Text	Saunders, George. <i>Congratulations, By the Way: Some Thoughts on Kindness</i>. Excerpts. Random House, 2014. (Used by permission of Random House, an imprint and division of Penguin Random House LLC. All rights reserved.) ▪ This graduation speech, delivered to students at Syracuse University in 2013, gives students experience with the genre of a commencement speech and serves as inspiration for their own speech.
Culminating Task	Each student will write, revise, and deliver to the class a graduation speech of their own. Depending on time and choice, the speeches may be presented live or as videos.
Rhetorical Concepts	• Rhetorical situation • Audience • Purpose • Occasion • Genre • Ethos, pathos, logos

Objectives	Integrated ELD: • Describe the ways that different aspects of the rhetorical situation—especially audience, purpose, occasion, and genre—influence a writer’s choices • Examine and reflect on strategies, processes, tools, and practices for ongoing learning and development • Analyze the extent to which the organization and style of a speech conform to or resist genre conventions • Engage in authentic intellectual conversations about important academic, personal, and societal issues and learning processes • Craft a successful public address that is appropriate to the moment • Participate as motivated, self-directed learners in collaborative group discussions, short oral presentations, and metacognitive reflection
Potential Mini-Module Pairings	• Introducing the Rhetorical Situation • Introducing Genre as Rhetoric • Introducing Kairos • Analyzing the Rhetorical Situation